DERECH HASHEM: THE RAMHAL'S WAY OF GOD, AT TIFERET EYAL

What Is Prophecy, Really?

Derech Hashem 3:3:4-7

Sefer: Derech Hashem by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Section:** Part 3, Chapter 3, paragraphs 4-7 (end of the chapter) **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Thursday 9 December 2021

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

From Ruah HaKodesh to prophecy

Last time: hokhmah is raw facts, binah is understanding one thing from another, and daat is when you feel it; when that comes intensely it is Ruah HaKodesh, and a flash of intuition is a spark of it. We have gone from dreams, to God's names, to changing nature, to Ruah HaKodesh. Now we reach the ultimate connection in this world: prophecy.

The Rabbi asked the group what prophecy is. One said a direct message from heaven; another, a message. "So both of you are wrong."

Paragraph 4: prophecy is cleaving

Above all of these is nevuah. Its essence is that a person reaches complete devekut, attachment to God, and actually feels it, almost tangibly, with no doubt at all. "Just like you don't have a doubt when I'm touching this, I'm touching something."

He gave an analogy from ethics. We all feel that stealing is wrong. We can offer reasons, but deep down we simply know it. So too the prophet simply knows he is cleaving to God. "You're cleaving. Not communicating."

With this connection comes understanding: deep matters and secrets of God, far clearer than Ruah HaKodesh. But messages are incidental. The proof: Hazal say that in Moshe's generation there were vast numbers of prophets. Where are all their messages? Yeshayahu and Yehezkel were also given messages to convey, but that was incidental to what prophecy is. Eldad and Medad prophesied in the camp without any message; they had simply reached that intense level.

A participant asked how this fits with the great hakhamim of our time. The Rabbi: however great they are, it is not the level of nevuah. He cannot describe it, never having had it, but it is clearly higher than anything there is today. He added that prophecy is one of the Thirteen Principles of Faith.

Paragraph 5: through a lens

Even this highest connection still comes through intermediaries. It is not face to face, but like looking through glass: "If you're outside, behind this, I can see you, but it's not the same as when I can actually have you in front of me." This is the *aspaklaria*, the lens or mirror, and its clarity varies from prophet to prophet. Only Moshe was "face to face", which will be a chapter of its own.

His image: sunglasses with yellow, blue or red lenses. "It's the same sun which is there. It's the same Kadosh Barukh Hu which is there." What changes is the lens.

A participant questioned the word "intermediary", which suggests an angel, rather than a barrier like glass. The Rabbi accepted "barrier" as a better word, and added that when we speak of God holding back His presence, God is always there; the barriers simply become thicker, until the glass is completely opaque.

Paragraph 6: the body cannot bear it

When the strong energy comes to the prophet, he is overwhelmed. His limbs tremble and feel as if they are being turned over. His senses cease, and his mental faculties no longer work on their own. The body cannot hold such intense spirituality; it is "like an allergic reaction", as the eyes squint and the head pulls away from a torch shone straight into them. The Torah describes the "great dark dread" that fell on Avraham at the Brit Bein HaBetarim: prophecy is a fearful experience. And at Matan Torah the people could not bear it.

This led to a lively question. If the senses stop, how did Avraham, in the middle of God's revelation, see three men approaching? The Rabbi suggested that seeing them was itself part of the communication, perhaps a test: would Avraham leave God to welcome guests? Avraham then returned to his physical senses to go to them. A participant suggested a level where the soul perceives directly as part of the communication, and the Rabbi agreed. He added that the prophets, except Moshe, could not initiate prophecy; God "came to" Avraham, which means God initiated the connection.

Paragraph 7: understanding fixed in the mind

Because the prophet is bound to the highest root, his understanding is raised far beyond anything the soul could reach alone. The revelation produces images in the prophet's imagination, and through them comes understanding that becomes fixed in his mind, so that he still knows it after returning to his senses. There are many levels of prophecy, explained in the next chapter, and above them all is Moshe, of whom the Torah testifies that no prophet arose like him.

Summary

- Prophecy is an intense, certain cleaving to God; messages are incidental.
- Every prophet but Moshe saw through a lens, clearer or darker according to his level.
- The body cannot bear prophecy: the senses shut down and the prophet trembles.
- The understanding gained in prophecy stays fixed in the mind afterwards.
- This level is far above anything available today.

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